

GLOSSARY

ABDOMEN

The hind part of the body. The abdomen lies below the ribcage in mammals, and behind the thorax in arthropods.

ACCESSORY FRUIT

A fruit that is formed from the flower's ovary and another structure, such as the swollen base of the flower. Examples of accessory fruits are apples and figs.

ADIPOSE FIN

A small fin behind the dorsal fin of a fish. It is mostly fatty tissue covered with skin.

AGARIC

Mushroom-like fruitbody of a fungus, consisting of stem and cap.

ALKALOID

Bitter, sometimes poisonous, chemical produced by certain plants or fungi.

ALLUVIAL (DEPOSIT)

Concentrations of material that have been separated by weathering from the host rock, then deposited in rivers or streams.

AMPHIBOLE

Group of common rock-forming minerals, often with complex composition. Most are ferro-magnesian silicates.

ANAL FIN

The unpaired fin of a fish on the lower side of its body, behind the anus.

ANGIOSPERM

A seed-producing plant that encloses its seeds in a fruit and produces flowers. *See also* gymnosperm.

ANNUAL

A plant that completes its life cycle, from germination to death, in a single season of growth.

ANTENNA (PL. ANTENNAE)

A sensory feeler on the head of arthropods and some other invertebrates, such as molluscs. Antennae are always present in pairs, and can be sensitive to touch, sound, heat, and taste. Their size and shape varies widely according to the way in which they are used.

ANTHER

In flowering plants, the pod-like structure on the stamen that produces pollen.

ANTLER

A bony growth on the head of deer. Unlike horns, antlers often branch, and in most cases they are grown and shed every year in a cycle linked with the breeding season.

ARBOREAL

Living fully or partly – known as semi-arboreal – in trees.

ASCUS (PL. ASCI)

Microscopic sac-like structure of sac fungi (Ascomycota) that produces spores.

ASEXUAL REPRODUCTION

A form of reproduction that involves just one parent, producing offspring that are genetically identical to each other (clones). It is most common in microbes, plants, and invertebrates.

BALEEN

A fibrous substance used by some whales for filtering food from water. Baleen grows in the form of plates with frayed edges, which hang from a whale's upper jaw. The baleen plates trap food, which the whale then swallows.

BASAL ANGIOSPERMS

Five orders of flowering plants with certain primitive features that diverged away from the main evolutionary line of flowering plants before others. Includes water lilies.

BASIDIUM (PL. BASIDIA)

Microscopic club-like structure of mushrooms and relatives (Basidiomycota) that produces spores.

BEAK

A set of narrow protruding jaws, usually without teeth. Beaks have evolved separately in many groups of vertebrates, including birds, tortoises, and some whales. The beak of a bird is also called a bill.

BERRY

A fleshy many-seeded fruit of a plant that develops from a single ovary. Many fruits popularly called berries are not true berries but compound fruits – an example of which is raspberry.

BIENNIAL

A plant that completes its life cycle, from germination to death, in two years. It typically stores up food in the first season that can be used for reproduction in the second season.

BIOLUMINESCENCE

The production of light by living organisms.

BIPEDAL

An animal that moves on two legs.

BRACKET

Shelf-like fruitbody of a fungus.

BRACT

Modified leaf, often brightly coloured, beneath a flower or flower cluster.

BROMELIAD

Flowering plant of the family Bromeliaceae. Almost exclusively tropical American, most live as rainforest epiphytes: perched in the rainforest branches without getting nourishment from the trees. Many form rosettes of leaves that collect rainwater, forming tree-top pools that are important nurseries of insect larvae and frog tadpoles.

BROWSER

An animal that feeds on the leaves of trees and shrubs rather than on grasses.

BULB

The underground shoot of a plant, consisting of modified leaves and used for food storage during periods of dormancy or for asexual reproduction.

CAECUM

Pouch of the digestive tract, often used in the digestion of plant food.

CALYX

Outer cup-like whorl of a flower, made up of sepals.

CAMOUFLAGE

Colours or patterns that enable an animal to merge with its background. It is often used for protection against predators and for concealment when approaching prey.

CANINE (TOOTH)

In mammals, a tooth with a single sharp point that is shaped for piercing and gripping prey. Canine teeth are located toward the front of the jaws, and are highly developed in carnivores.

CARAPACE

A hard shield on the back of some animals, including crustaceans, arachnids, and some reptiles. In turtles and tortoises, the carapace is the upper part of the shell.

CARBOHYDRATE

Foodstuff, such as sugar or starch, that provides energy.

CARNASSIAL (TOOTH)

In mammalian carnivores, a blade-like upper premolar and lower molar tooth that have evolved for slicing through flesh.

CARNIVORE

Any animal that eats meat. The word carnivore can also be used in a more restricted sense to mean mammals of the order Carnivora.

CARPEL

Female reproductive part of a flower, divided into ovary, style, and stigma. Also known as the pistil.

CARTILAGE

A rubbery substance forming part of vertebrate skeletons. In most vertebrates, it lines the joints, but in cartilaginous fish it forms the whole skeleton.

CATKIN

Hanging cluster of flowers, usually with simple flowers all of the same sex.

CELL

The smallest unit of an organism that can exist on its own.

CELLULOSE

A complex carbohydrate found in plants. It is used by plants as building material, and has a resilient chemical structure that animals find hard to digest. Plant-eating animals break it down in their stomach with the aid of micro-organisms.

CHITIN

A tough carbohydrate making up cell walls of fungi and certain animal exoskeletons.

CHLOROPHYLL

Green pigment found in chloroplasts used to trap light energy in photosynthesis.

CHLOROPLAST

Granule inside the cell of a photosynthesizing eukaryote used for photosynthesis. *See* photosynthesis.

CHROMOSOME

Microscopic filament inside a cell that carries genetic information (DNA).

CLIMBER

A plant that grows up a vertical surface, such as a rock or a tree, using it for support. Climbers do not gain nourishment from other plants, but may weaken them by blocking out light.

CLOACA

An opening towards the rear of the body that is shared by several body systems. In some vertebrates – such as bony fish and amphibians – the gut, kidneys, and reproductive systems all use this opening, mainly for waste.

CLONES

Genetically identical individuals. Two or more identical organisms that share exactly the same genes.

CLOVEN-HOOFED

Having hoofs that look as though they are split in half. Most cloven-hoofed mammals, such as deer and antelope, actually have two hoofs, arranged on either side of a line that divides the foot in two.

COCOON

A case made of open, woven silk. Many insects spin a cocoon before they begin pupation, and many spiders spin one to hold their eggs.

COLONY

A group of animals belonging to the same species that spend their lives together, often dividing up the tasks involved in survival. In some colonial species, particularly aquatic invertebrates, the colony members are permanently fastened together. In others, such as ants, bees, and wasps, members forage for food independently but live in the same nest.

COMMENSAL

Living in close relationship with another species without either helping it or damaging it.

COMPOUND

A substance made up of two or more elements chemically reacted together.

COMPOUND EYE

An eye that is divided into separate compartments, each with its own set of lenses. The number of compartments the eye can contain varies from a few dozen to thousands. Compound eyes are a common feature of arthropods.

COMPOUND LEAF

A leaf with a blade divided into smaller leaflets. *See also* simple leaf.